



NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 04

Urban: Toilet Infrastructure

WASH in India

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URBAN: TOILET INFRASTRUCTURE

WASH IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

Sanitation infrastructure and toilets in urban India have grown significantly due to efforts under the Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) (SBM-U) 1.0 and 2.0. Since the program's launch, the number of urban households without access to toilets has decreased yearly, with just under 3% of urban households lacking toilet access as of 2022.¹ Public and community toilets (PTs and CTs) have also been constructed extensively for the urban poor, homeless, migrants, and others lacking household toilet access. Adopting effective urban toilet infrastructure practices in India can lead to improved health outcomes, increased workforce productivity, and improved education outcomes for females.

However, there is a need to address a few challenges. While substantial advances in technology and financing of faecal sludge management and grey water have taken place, only 34% of urban toilets are connected to sewer systems leading to unhygienic waste management.² Additionally, women and adolescent girls encounter difficulties using public toilets and community toilets due to poor location, inappropriate design, and inadequate maintenance.³ Further, there is a need to create awareness about hygiene, water conservation, and safe sanitation practices including treating CTs like household toilets.⁴

Given these opportunities and challenges, ongoing maintenance and upgrades to toilet and sewage infrastructure and citizen engagement and information are the major policy focus areas. Several ongoing and recent central government initiatives, including but not limited to Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban 2.0 and Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation 2.0 focus on promoting inclusive toilet infrastructure, IEC campaigns for behavioural change, and universal sewer and septage coverage. These efforts, along with state and local initiatives, aim to ensure that India achieves a comprehensive and accessible urban toilet infrastructure, promoting sanitation and public health.

Figure 1: Key urban toilet infrastructure statistics

97%

Urban households with access to any type of toilet or latrine facility

107%

Achievement of individual household latrines constructed (63.04 lacs) against the Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban target (58.99 lacs)

125%

Achievement of community and public toilets constructed (6.37 lacs) against the Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban target (5.08 lacs)

Source: Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Swachh Bharat Mission Urban 2.0, accessed December 2023; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-5, 2019-21

1 MoSPI, Multiple Indicator Survey of Indi 2020-21, 2023; ORGI, Availability and type of latrine facility -2001, 2011, 2022

2 WHO, UNICEF, JMP WASH Data- Sanitation in India, accessed 5 July 2023; NITI Aayog & NFSSM Alliance, Faecal Sludge and Septage Management in Urban Areas, 2021

3 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

4 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

Key trends

This section dives deeper into India's urban toilet infrastructure landscape, outlining statistics and trends on:

1. Household Latrines
2. Community & Public Toilets
3. IEC & Citizen Engagement

Household Latrines

Individual household latrines have been constructed rapidly since the launch of SBM-U 1.0. Central and state support and financing instruments from financial institutions have allowed families access to private sanitation. This has helped reduce open defecation, increased productivity, and empowered minorities, women, and marginalized communities.

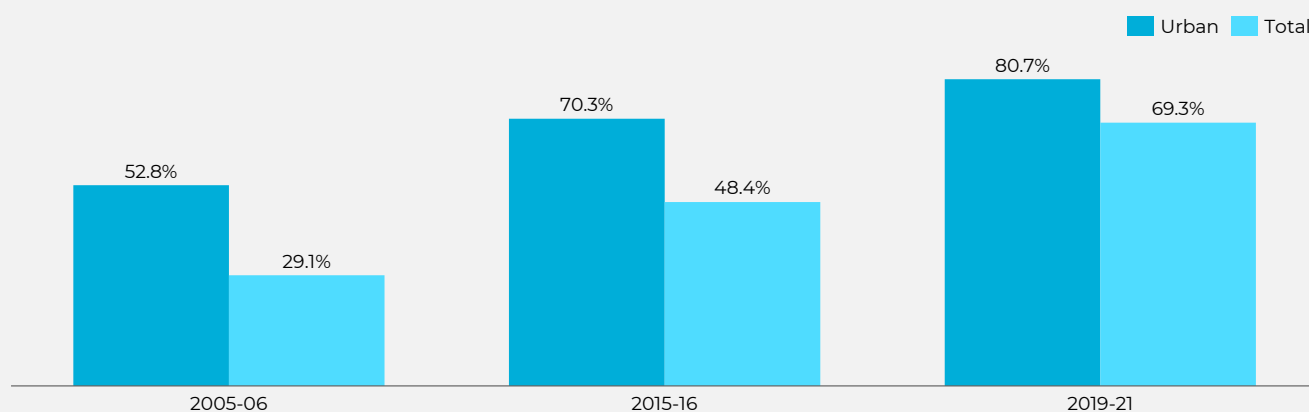
The Swachh Bharat Mission – Urban scheme has exceeded toilet construction targets:

By 2023, the SBM-U scheme had constructed nearly 6.3 million individual household latrines as against the target of 5.9 million individual latrines.⁵

Access to improved toilets has grown substantially since 2005:

Urban residents with access to improved toilet facilities that are non-shared increased from 53% in 2005-06 to 81% in 2019-21.⁶

Figure 2: Share of urban households with access to an improved (not shared) toilet facility in India (2005-06 to 2019-21)



Source: Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-5 (2019-21), 2021; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-3 (2015-16), 2017; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-3 (2005-06), 2007

Community & Public Toilets

Community toilets (CTs) refer to shared facilities provided for a relatively fixed group of residents or a community/ settlement. Public toilets (PTs) include toilets constructed in high-footfall

⁵ Swachh Bharat Mission Urban, Achievements, accessed June 2023

⁶ Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) and ICF, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019-21: India: Volume I, 2022; Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) and ICF, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-3), 2005-06: India: Volume I, 2007

regions such as bus stations, railway stations, and parks.⁷ CTs and PTs form an integral part of the SBM open defecation-free plus approach.

The Swacch Bharat Mission – Urban scheme has exceeded CT and PT construction targets in urban areas:

By 2023, the SBM-U scheme had constructed over 600,000 CTs and PTs as against the target of 507,587.⁸

Figure 2: Community and public toilet construction by state and UT, 2023

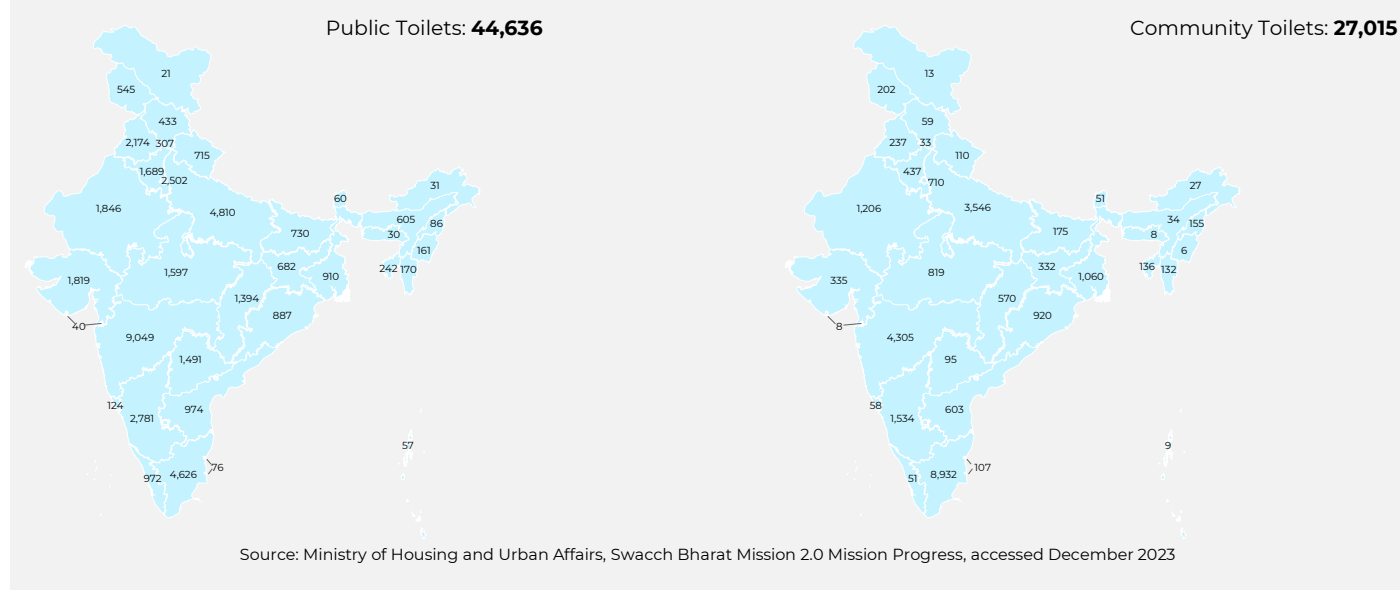
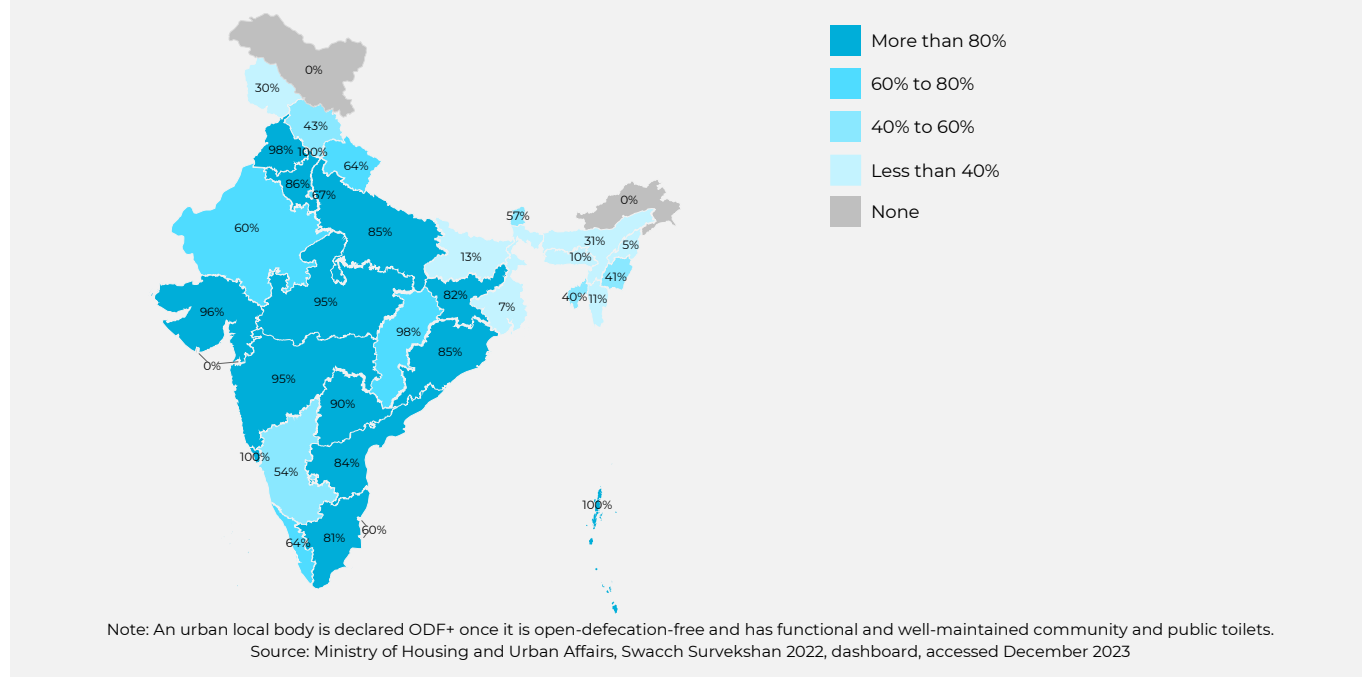


Figure 3: Share of urban local bodies declared ODF+ by state and UT, 2023



⁷ MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

⁸ Swacch Bharat Mission Urban, Achievements, accessed December 2023

IEC & Citizen Engagement

The SBM-U has emphasized sanitation-related behaviour change across urban India, including increasing toilet usage to reduce open defecation rates. Citizens are encouraged to play an active role in ensuring safe and clean toilet use and maintenance.

Funds allocated for citizen engagement and awareness have led to sanitation emerging as a key focus area within urban communities:

Under SBM-U, a part of the central allocation is earmarked for IEC and public awareness.⁹ Over the years, sanitation has become a very visible topic with high recall in urban India, supported by 360-degree communication efforts that span interpersonal, mid-media, and mass media efforts¹⁰. Behaviour change communication covers issues of open defecation, prevention of manual scavenging, hygiene practices, toilet technologies, and proper use and maintenance of toilet facilities.¹¹

⁹ MoHUA, Swachh Bharat Mission – Urban 2.0, 2017

¹⁰ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Manual: IEC for ODF Plus, 2021; Orissa Water Supply & Sewerage Board, Odisha's Journey of Faecal Sludge and Septage Management, 2018

¹¹ MoHUA, Swachh Bharat Mission – Urban 2.0, 2017

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective urban toilet infrastructure practices. These revolve primarily around the potential for ensuring sound health, greater productivity, improved education outcomes, and higher engagement by different stakeholders.



Improvement in health outcomes:

Research indicates that the lack of regular handwashing and microbial water contamination in homes and communities contribute to nearly 100,000 diarrheal deaths of children under five years in India annually.¹² Access to proper sanitation facilities, including toilets, encourages hygienic practices and improves public health.¹³



Increase in workforce productivity:

When workers have access to proper sanitation facilities, they experience better health, leading to fewer sick days and improved productivity.¹⁴ By investing in sanitation services in the workplace, businesses can generate public benefits and create opportunities for growth and profitability.



Improvement in education outcomes for females:

A quarter of all girls in schools in India take time off when menstruating because of the lack of gender-specific toilets, and the non-availability of sanitary pads in schools. A report by UNICEF notes that the presence of separate toilets, alongside other menstrual hygiene facilities, can help females stay in school and reduce dropout and absenteeism.¹⁵



Improved service levels through private sector engagement:

The National Urban Sanitation Policy emphasises the promotion of partnerships between public, private and non-governmental agencies to improve the provision, maintenance, and management of sanitation facilities. The policy views driving coordinated action as essential through activities like leveraging private investments as well as the planning and implementation of programs.¹⁶

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing urban toilet infrastructure practices in India. Efforts to resolve such challenges will ensure high-quality toilet facilities, greater awareness, and improved well-being of sanitation workers.



Insufficient facilities and high subsequent costs for household toilets:

Some people from urban households still defecate in the open due to reasons such as insufficient toilet facilities, running water, and proper containment systems.¹⁷ Moreover, existing toilet structures have high maintenance costs- 64% of urban toilets rely on “on-site

¹² UNICEF, Water, sanitation and hygiene, accessed 2023

¹³ UNICEF, Sanitation, accessed 2023

¹⁴ UNICEF, Call To Actions For Business To Invest In Wash, accessed August 2023

¹⁵ UNICEF, Clean India - Clean schools, accessed 2023

¹⁶ MoHUA, National Urban Sanitation Policy, accessed December 2023

¹⁷ MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018; International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) and ICF, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019-21: India: Volume I, 2022

sanitation” (OSS) where septic tanks require periodic cleaning, maintenance, and emptying.¹⁸ Such high emptying charges dissuade poor and low-income households from using toilets, leading to inequitable gaps in usage.¹⁹



Inadequate safety, cleanliness, and quality of Community and Public toilets (CTs and PTs):

Women and adolescent girls face challenges in using PTs and CTs due to poor location, inappropriate design, and inadequate maintenance.²⁰ Common issues with projects include subpar construction quality, lack of operator ownership, and divided responsibilities between contractors and operators. This results in minimal attention to routine maintenance and repairs until ULB intervention is sought.²¹



Limited impact of IEC programs on toilet maintenance, especially for CTs:

A MoHUA report notes a general lack of awareness about hygiene, water conservation, and safe sanitation practices.²² It underscores the need for developing initiatives to encourage people to follow the right practices regarding smoking, spitting paan, and treating CTs like household toilets.²³



Prejudicial social norms against sanitation workers:

Sanitation workers play a critical role in maintaining public health and cleanliness. Despite their invaluable contribution, they frequently encounter societal prejudice, marginalization, and limited access to basic rights and services. Discrimination against sanitation workers perpetuates a cycle of disadvantage, hindering their well-being and hampering the overall progress of communities.²⁴

18 WHO, UNICEF, JMP WASH Data- Sanitation in India, accessed 5 July 2023

19 NITI Aayog, Faecal Sludge and Septage Management in urban areas, 2021

20 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

21 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

22 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

23 MoHUA, Advisory on Public and Community Toilets, 2018

24 SBM Urban, Training module for sanitary workers on cleaning of sewers and septic tanks, 2020

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee urban toilet infrastructure and related practices.



Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs:

The Ministry is concerned with matters related to urban development and aims to tackle the various challenges that arise in the wake of rapid urbanisation in India. This includes themes around housing, poverty, unemployment, the development of health, sanitation, education infrastructure, and so on.²⁵ Thus overseeing and implementing policies around ensuring good quality urban toilet infrastructure also falls under its ambit.

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing schemes related to urban toilet infrastructure and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.



Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban 2.0²⁶:

The SBM-U 2.0 seeks to achieve “ODF++” status for all cities in India. Some of the key measures the mission aims to take up for sustainable development and maintenance of toilet infrastructure are:

- Supporting the conversion of insanitary latrines into sanitary ones, construction of individual household latrines, community sanitary complexes, and public toilets, while also ensuring inclusive design.
- Attracting private sector investments in the sanitation economy
- Emphasising mechanised cleaning of septic tanks and sewers, thus reducing reliance on sanitation workers
- Undertaking IEC campaigns for sustained use of toilet infrastructure, and supporting capacity-building of stakeholders involved in planning, implementing, and monitoring



Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation 2.0²⁷:

AMRUT 2.0 is a step towards making cities “water secure” and ensuring the provision of functional water tap connections for all Indian households. One of the key components of the mission is focused on sewerage, septage management and recycling/reuse of treated used water. It aims to provide universal sewer and septage coverage in 500 cities by 2026.

²⁵ Lok Sabha Secretariat, Background Note on “Housing and Urban Affairs”, 2021

²⁶ MoHUA, Swachh Bharat Mission - Urban Guidelines, 2021

²⁷ Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation 2.0, 2021

Way forward

As this note highlights, India has made substantial progress on urban toilet infrastructure over the last 10 years. A very large fraction of the urban population now has access to toilets either within their household premises or, for a smaller number, within their community. Also, sanitation has become a very visible topic thanks to the constant focus on this through different channels and sustained IEC efforts.

Going forward, there is a significant opportunity to fully realize the benefits of this progress, and achieve significant improvements in health outcomes for citizens, equity outcomes for sanitation workers, and also economic and environmental outcomes overall.

Some focus areas that can drive progress include:

 Improving the safety of waste disposal systems	• Ensure safe disposal by prioritising the connection of toilets to (i) sewage networks where possible (ii) safely managed onsite storage systems in areas lacking sewage networks. • Track the progress of toilet connections and onsite storage systems across various states with high accuracy and granularity
 Design and scale-inclusive toilet infrastructure	• Prioritize toilets accessible and convenient for women, girls, and people with disabilities in the next phase of infrastructure development by collaborating with inclusive design experts and community groups to retrofit or redesign existing toilets across all states for increased usability by these groups
 Increasing operations & maintenance support	• Partner with financial organizations like philanthropies and impact investors to create dedicated funds for the operation and maintenance of household-level, shared, and community-level toilets • Implement digital payment systems in community and public toilets to enhance sustainability and ease of use for residents
 Providing sustained support to sanitation workers	• Provide sanitation workers with ongoing support, training, and safety equipment to facilitate their work effectively and safely • Advocate for and implement comprehensive safety measures or policies to ensure worker safety and address challenges faced by sanitation workers across states

Recommended readings

Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. (2018). *Advisory on Public and Community Toilets*
<https://cpheeo.gov.in/upload/whatsnew/5c0a08232e7afAdvisory%20on%20public%20toilet.pdf>

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National Institute of Urban Affairs, USAID. (2018). *Innovative toilet concepts for urban India*
<https://niua.in/intranet/sites/default/files/2619.pdf>

Institute for Social and Economic Change. (2017). *Improving toilet access among the urban poor*
<http://www.isec.ac.in/PB%2013%20Manasi%20Policy%20Brief%20Sanitation%20final.pdf>



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